performance in writer Ved Mehta's book, *Portrait of India* (1970), and reached out to her. Or how, in order to work in the US, she asked a stranger she saw outside New York's Museum of Modern Art to marry her—and he agreed. Though they subsequently divorced, Puthli says "he will always be in my life, he is my best friend".

She believes the reason her music is now getting the global recognition she has long aspired for is because "the time is right not just for me, but for a lot of young South Asians; there's a bigger [diasporic] population in America and England".

The difference between the 1970s-80s when she tried to break into the mainstream and now is that the diaspora is not only larger "but they're much more assimilated because they grew up here. So it's easier now for labels to [believe they] have a target market". In 2022, singer-songwriter Raveena Aurora, among the desi acts making waves today, paid tribute to Puthli by naming her last album, *Asha's Awakening*.

Mumbai-based Bang Bang Films is producing a documentary about Puthli, while she is simultaneously, if intermittently, writing her autobiography. "It's in the process even if it's haphazard," she says. "I think in tangents. I'll remember something and put it down. It's splishing and splashing, and maybe I'll get a bucket of water from it." ■

–Amit Gurbaxani

MUSIC

Hitting a Winning Streak

OTT roles, a new music album and part of Lollapalooza India's line-up, it seems like American artiste Lisa Mishra is here to stay

It's raining accolades for Lisa Mishra. On the day we catch up for this interview, the OTT series in which she has made her India debut, *Call Me Bae*, is number one in the country and all across South Asia on Prime Video. And the song 'Yaara Tere Bin' that she composed for the series is already topping the charts in Mumbai. If you've watched the series, you've probably noted the inherent talent and good looks of the Indian-born, American-bred musician and actor, who plays the role of channel producer Harleen. Not only will you be seeing more of her in the upcoming series *Royals* and at the Lollapalooza India 2025 music fest in Mumbai, she's definitely going to be slaying it all round in the years to come.

Living in Chicago where her family moved when she was six, she admits that she grew up on a diet of Indian pop music and Bollywood songs. Powerful female pop musicians and big ballads are her thing even today and singers Sunidhi Chauhan and Beyoncé are her guiding lights. The self-trained singer, whose latest album *Sorry, I'm Late* garnered much appreciation on its release earlier this year, started young. She had a YouTube channel by the time she was 13, showed off her vocals on a Grammy-winning album by Chance the Rapper, has had a host of amazing collabs... and then came the mash-up that changed her life in 2018.

"Many people do mash-ups now. But at the time the 'Tareefan' cover happened on Instagram, there were actually very few of us doing this. It was mainly Vidya Vox and me in the Hindi-English cross-over space," says Mishra, whose first Hindi cover, 'Kabira', went viral. "Actually, that is the most viewed video of mine, more so than even 'Tareefan' (which she reprised for the film, *Veere di Wedding*). When I posted it, I realised there was a huge fan base in India that I had never tapped into," she shares.

It was right after this that she moved to India to see where her talent took her. She confesses, "It was a big challenge for me in the studio, because I didn't speak Hindi! Craft demands time and you physically being there, else you'll never be as authentic as a native speaker."

Nevertheless, Mishra's portrayal of Harleen is effortless and evocative. She believes that her character in the upcoming *Royals*, set in Rajasthan, is "kind of from the same world as Harleen" and that they could have been besties had they inhabited the same universe. Whether we'll see the '*behen* code' manifesting or not, we know that with Mishra, an empowered female narrative will never be far away. ■

–Priya Pathiyan



Singer **Lisa Mishra** made her acting debut with a role in the OTT series, Call Me Bae, and will soon be seen again in Royals, set in Rajasthan